

Session 23: Consequences of the Fail

Key Takeaways

- The word *'itsabon* means “emotional grief and anguish,” and it is used to characterize the consequences for the man and the woman in Genesis 3:16-19. It does not describe physical pain during childbirth as a punishment for the woman’s failure.
- In response to human failure, God sorrowfully hands people over to the consequences of their choices, but he does not delight in heaping suffering on them.

The Juxtaposition of Genesis 3:15 and 3:16

Genesis 3:15 tells us that there will be struggle between personal forces of rebellion that carry on the legacy of the snake and the seed of the woman. We also learn that this struggle will result in a conflict that wounds both the snake and the seed. However this happens, it’s clear that childbirth is at the heart of this conflict and also the strange vehicle of God’s rescue.

The next verse, Genesis 3:16, focuses on the fraught reality of childbirth, which is the unique and privileged role of the woman. It will take place in the middle of struggle and grief, but at the same time, the birth of the promised seed is the hope of future restoration.

The pain surrounding the entry of every child into the world is a paradoxical reminder of the future hope of creation’s rescue. It makes perfect sense, then, why the pain of childbirth becomes a powerful biblical image of suffering leading to redemption (Rom. 8:22-24; Matt. 24:8).

Consequences for the Woman: Genesis 3:16

Let’s look at a couple different translations of the first half of Genesis 3:16. To the common reader, these translations seem to associate pain with giving labor. But is that what is going on here?

Genesis 3:16a NIV

I will make your pains in childbearing very severe; with painful labor you will give birth to children.

Genesis 3:16a ESV

I will surely multiply your pain in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children.

Pain in Childbirth?

Interestingly, the word grief or pain (Heb. *'itsabon*) is not the Hebrew word for labor pains. The same word, *'itsabon*, is used in the next verse, [Genesis 3:17](#), to refer to the frustrating toil the man will experience in the field (see also [Gen. 5:29](#); [Isa. 14:3](#)). Additionally, the word grief/pain is applied to the noun “conception” (Heb. *herayon*) which is explicitly *not* labor pain.

The root of *'itsabon* is widely used in biblical Hebrew and is best understood as “grief” or “hurtful” (*'atsab* / עֲצַב). Take a look at the word used as a verb describing the emotional experience of grief or sadness.

Genesis 6:6 NIV*

The Lord regretted that he had made human beings on the earth, and his heart was **'atsab**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 54:6 NIV*

“The LORD will call you back as if you were a wife deserted and **'atsab** in spirit—a wife who married young, only to be rejected” says your God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The root word also appears as a noun: *'Otseb* or *'etseb* (עֲצַב). This word can be used to refer to a combined physical or emotional pain that results from difficult work circumstances.

2 Samuel 19:1-2 NIV*

¹ Joab was told, “The king is weeping and mourning for Absalom.” ² And for the whole army the victory that day was turned into mourning, because on that day the troops heard it said, “The king is **'atsab** for his son.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Proverbs 15:1 NASB*

A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a word of **'otseb** stirs up anger.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Proverbs 10:22 NIV*

The blessing of the Lord brings wealth, without **'etseb** for it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 147:2-3 NIV*

² The Lord builds up Jerusalem;
he gathers the exiles of Israel.

³ He heals the brokenhearted
and binds up their **'otseb**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Proverbs 14:23 NIV*

All **'etseb** brings a profit, but mere talk leads only to poverty.

"[The word 'etseb] is used of emotional pain and the pain involved in work. It can also be used of a more generalized kind of pain. Is is never used elsewhere in the Old Testament, however, to refer to labor pains, or 'birthpangs.' Conversely, there is a well-established vocabulary which is routinely used to labor pain: tsarar (צָרָר, *khebel* חָבַל, and *khul* חוּל ... If we take our lead from the meaning of 'etseb עֵצֵב elsewhere in the Old Testament, Genesis 3:16 refers to the agony, hardship, worry, and anxiety of the circumstances in which children are conceived, born and raised, and in which they die. ... This is the same word's clear meaning when describing the man's work in the field in the very next verse (Gen. 3:17)."

Provan, Iain (2012). "Pain in Childbirth?" In *Let Us Go Up to Zion*. Brill.

"The 'pain' of 3:16 ought not be understood as the physical pain of childbirth, but of the unrelenting labor required even of pregnant mothers in a pre-industrial, agrarian subsistence economy, and the concomitant psychological stresses of motherhood in such a milieu."

Heard, Christopher (2003). "An Intertextual Reading of Jabez' Prayer in 1 Chronicles 4:9-10." *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*.

After study and reflection, we think the following translation of Genesis 3:16a is a better reflection of how these words are used in the Hebrew Bible.

Genesis 3:16a Instructor's Translation

I will greatly multiply your grief and your conception, in grief you will birth children.

He Will Rule Over You?

This interpretation of Genesis 3:16a makes even more sense in the light of Genesis 3:16b.

Genesis 3:16b NASB

Your desire will be for your husband, but he will rule over you.

The key interpretive question is whether this is a comparison or a contrast, and whether the key words, "desire" and "rule," are to be taken as positive or negative. This results in four different interpretations of this sentence.

Interpretation 1: Contrast

Genesis 3:16b NASB*

Your **desire [negative]** will be for your husband,
but he will **rule [positive]** over you.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The woman's "desire" is a negative one used to control and manipulate her husband, in line with her deceptive behavior in giving him the fruit that she took. In contrast, and as a punishment of sorts, God appoints that

man rules woman as her authority. The ESV translation provides an interpretive translation that points in this direction: “Your desire will be contrary to your husband, but he will rule over you.”

Problems with Interpretation 1

- Genesis 3:6-7 does not portray the woman as acting against the will of her husband. On the contrary, he is right next to her! And God holds both of them accountable for the act, not just the woman. She is not portrayed as more culpable than the man, so these words are a punishment.
- The man “ruling” the woman is a direct inversion of God’s ideal will for humanity in Genesis 1:26-28 that male and female rule together.

Interpretation 2: Contrast

Genesis 3:16b NASB*

Your **desire [positive]** will be for your husband,
but he will **rule [negative]** over you.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The woman’s desire is viewed as a natural or instinctual kind of submissive desire while, unfortunately, the man’s desire is for aggressive control of the woman. This interpretation sees Genesis 3:16b as a kind of reflection on the “nature” of gender relations.

Problems with Interpretation 2

- This very narrow and biased view of gender relations makes faulty, sweeping assumptions (as if all men have power complexes in relation to women and all women have positive feelings about men!).
- It is hard to see how this interpretation contributes to the context of Genesis 3:16a or the broader context of the story, where the man and woman are clearly at odds with each other in Genesis 3:8-13.

Interpretation 3: Comparison

Genesis 3:16b NASB*

Your **desire [positive]** will be for your husband,
but he will **rule [positive]** over you.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The woman’s positive desire will be a submissive one for her husband’s love, and in return, he rules her with divinely granted authority. This view describes the ideal relation between genders from a Christian hierarchical point of view.

Problems with Interpretation 3

- Biblical scholars agree that Genesis 3:16b is not making a positive, ideal statement. This interpretation is a logical possibility, but not likely given the context that God is giving bad news in Genesis 3:14-19.

Interpretation 4: Comparison

Genesis 3:16b NASB*

Your **desire [negative]** will be for your husband,
but he will **rule [negative]** over you.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The woman's desires will be in contrast to her husband's desires, generating conflict between them, and in response, the man will make a powerplay over the woman to control and subdue her.

This is God's sad and realistic warning of the new normal for the man and woman outside of Eden. Now that each person "does what is good in their own eyes," the ideal of [Genesis 1:26-28](#) for male and female to rule together is tragically distorted. Women desire to subvert their husbands, and men return the favor.

Strengths of Interpretation 4

This interpretation fits into the larger context perfectly, as it represents a sad inversion of both ideals in Genesis 1:26-28 (ruling together) and Genesis 2:18-25 (naked intimacy and desirable union).

- The rare word "desire" (*teshuqah* / תְּשׁוּקָה) is used only two times elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible, both hyperlinked to Genesis 3:16b.
- Genesis 4:7 is a clever hyperlink: "[sin's] desire is for you, and you can rule it." Here the desire of "sin" for Cain is a negative desire to control his actions and consume him like an animal.
- Song of Songs 7:10: "I belong to my beloved, and his desire is for me." This is also a clever hyperlink back to Genesis 3:16, where the idealized male and female lovers (in the garden of the song) reverse the tragic reality of Eden back into its ideal. Song of Songs 7:10 represents the undoing of the fracture between man and woman in Genesis 3:16! Here the "desire" is positive, precisely in contrast to Genesis 3:16.
- The man "ruling" the woman is the precise opposite picture of God's ideal in Genesis 1-2, where male and female rule together (Gen. 1:26-28), and where the woman is set apart from the animals not as the man's inferior but as his equal (from his "side").
- The rest of the book of Genesis is a series of narrative embodiments of this interpretation of Genesis 3:16. Every generation will experience moments where a woman desires power and control over her husband, which is met by a response of manipulation and powerplay in return: Abraham and Sarai ([Gen. 12:10-20](#); [Gen. 16:1-16](#)), Isaac and Rebekah ([Gen. 27:1-46](#)), Jacob and Rachel and Leah ([Gen. 29:1-30:43](#)), Judah and Tamar ([Gen. 38:1-30](#)), etc.

"The man's fate [in Gen. 3:17] ... matches the woman's. He will know grievous toil ('etseb) as she does. Here it certainly refers to challenging economic circumstances, as the man is locked in a struggle with the land, hoping through 'painful toil' to grow sufficient green plants in the midst of 'thorns and thistles' to survive. The work done in the field corresponds to the work done at home (notice that the woman's 'etseb is said to increase, not to begin) ... The man is not only in a struggle with the land, but Gen. 3:16 tells us that he's also locked in a struggle with his spouse. ... Men and women are created to work and rule in partnership ... but now the man relates to the woman as if she were a part of the creation, rather than a co-ruler over creation with the man. And she, for her part, is not portrayed as blameless in this increased dysfunctionality in male-female relations. ... Intended for partnership, they will in fact find themselves embroiled in a struggle for dominance. ... This is why family life will be more 'painful' for the woman ... dysfunction now marks not only

the human relationship with God and with the land, but also with each other. The remainder of the book of Genesis powerfully illustrated this dysfunction and the sorrow that it brings.”
Provan, Iain (2012). *“Pain in Childbirth?”* In *Let Us Go Up to Zion*. Brill.

Consequences for the Man: Genesis 3:17-19

Genesis 3:17a Instructor’s Translation

“Because you listened (*shama’* / קוֹל) to the voice (*qol* / קוֹל) of your wife”

This phrase refers back to his “taking and eating” in Genesis 3:6, which also provides a contrast to his fearful response when God entered the garden in Genesis 3:10: “I listened (*shama’* / שמע) to your sound/voice (*qol* / קוֹל) in the garden.”

Instead of “listening to the voice of God” about the tree, he ate from it after “listening to the voice” of his wife. This introduction of the key phrase prepares the reader for many later narratives where “listening to the voice” becomes a synonym for someone’s moral failure on analogy with Genesis 3:1-24 (Gen. 16:2; Gen. 27:8), or their moral victory that reverses Genesis 3:1-24 (Gen. 22:18).

Genesis 3:17b Instructor’s Translation

“Cursed is the land on account of you ...”

Instead of experiencing God’s uninhibited blessing of abundance in the land, humanity will have to struggle with a land outside of Eden that easily produces inedible plants (“thorns and thistles”) and grows edible food only with “grievous toil.”

Genesis 3:18 Instructor’s Translation

“You will eat the vegetation of the field (*‘eseb hassadeh* / עֵשֶׂב הַשָּׂדֶה)”

Outside of Eden, humanity is reduced to the food that was explicitly assigned to the animals in Genesis 1:30: “to every living creature of the land, every bird ... and creeper on the land ... the green vegetation (*‘eseb* / עֵשֶׂב) will be for food.”

Instead of eating from the easily cultivated fruit trees of Eden that produce food by themselves, humanity will be forced to coax the ground to produce vegetation (3:18) that can be made into “bread” (3:19).

Genesis 3:19 Instructor’s Translation

“By the sweat of your brow ... until you return to the ground, for from it you were taken”

Subsistence agriculture is backbreaking work that reduces humans to servants of the ground and grinds them back into the dust. This is in contrast to the easily enjoyed food of the cultivated garden. These

words also link forward to Genesis 3:22, which tells us humanity would have achieved immortality only if they had access to God's presence through the tree of life.

Genesis 3:17-19 has profound implications. The Eden narrative presents the dirt-humans as mortal by nature. Immortality was not inherent to human nature but a gift that was forfeited and never attained. Instead of falling from perfection into death, Genesis 2-3 is a story about a failure to receive God's gift of eternal life. Perhaps we should begin calling Genesis 3 "the fail" instead of "the fall."

"[The punishment is] that work will now involve more pain than before. The work will be experienced in a different way—as a struggle with an earth that is more reluctant to give up good things, and that insists on producing 'thorns and thistles for you' (Gen. 3:8). The wording of this verse is strange, and underlines that it is not the world that has changed but people's experience of this world ... The land will still provide food, but only at a greater cost."

Provan, Iain (2014). [*Seriously Dangerous Religion: What the Old Testament Really Says and Why It Matters*](#). Baylor University Press.

Reflection Question

In Genesis 3:16-17, God says to the woman that she will experience pain related to bearing children. What kind of pain does it seem like God is talking about?